

mother of all match-ups has seen both camps play the media like a Stradivarius. Nothing is unplanned or unscripted, from the laughter on call and tears on cue coordinated by Bhansali at *Saawariya*'s music release, where Ranbir Kapoor's parents Rishi and Neetu Kapoor came hand-in-hand with Sonam Kapoor's parents, Anil and Sunita Kapoor, to Padukone's face adorning *Vogue India*'s second cover (the launch issue had featured a spread on the sets of *Saawariya* and a profile of Sonam). If the *Om Shanti Om* team featured in an episode of Zee TV's *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa* and Star Plus' *Nach Baliye 3*, Columbia Tristar got Ranbir and Sonam to shoot for Star Plus' *Amul Star Voice of India* and Sony's *Jhalak Dikhla Jaa*, after their parents, of course.

Marketing analysts estimate the advertising that *Saawariya* has managed

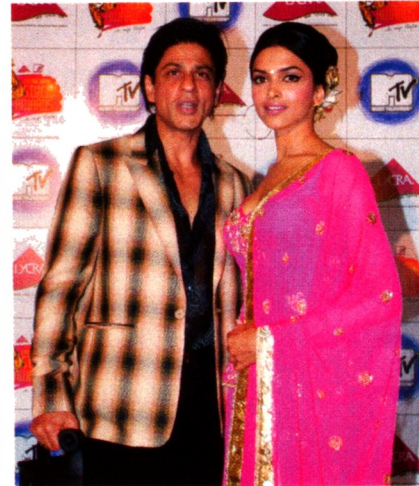
tidy profit (Eros has bought the film for a reported Rs 74 crore excluding music rights, which have gone to T-Series, and satellite rights, which are still up for grabs) he would certainly like the film to get the better opening. For Sony, it is their first Hindi film in India, being launched with pedigreed actors, who have their own legacies to live up to. Ranbir and Sonam Kapoor have been

Mukherji are also lined up. Bhansali's idea is to keep everything on a "warm simmer". Sony has hired a marketing agency, P9, to do brand deals, while *Om Shanti Om*'s are being handled by Madison Mates.

Shah Rukh's strategy is clear: divide the appearances between himself, his director Farah Khan, pregnant with triplets, and his new heroine, who has a thriving career as a fashion model. But mostly he is playing it by the ear. As he puts it: "There are so many platforms and visibility arenas. We spend where and when we need to. But a lot of stuff is free." Indeed, as he cheekily told a channel: "I thought I would have to do a lot more promotion but you guys have made it so easy for me." So is it not a marketing overkill? Hype around a

EQUAL AND OPPOSITE REACTION: *Saawariya* and *Om Shanti Om* on TV

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from tie-ups with Citibank (in six countries except India), Reliance Insurance, Xylitol bubblegum, Airtel and Sony products is worth Rs 10 crore in air-time. *Om Shanti Om*'s tie-ups with Nokia, Maybelline and Sia Jewellery are worth Rs 5 crore in terms of advertising time. The fight has extended to fashion with Pantaloon to supply Rs 15 crore worth of *Saawariya* merchandise to its 70-odd outlets while Shopper's Stop will hawk *Om Shanti Om*'s '70's-inspired retro-fit clothes worth Rs 4 crore at its 20 outlets. That's not all. If *Saawariya* had tied up with Neo Sports, *Om Shanti Om* had MTV *Lycra Awards*. If *Saawariya* has a premiere in New York, *Om Shanti Om* has one in London.

For the actors, much is at stake. This is Shah Rukh's own production and though he is already sitting on a

SAAWARIYA

MOVIE BUDGET: Rs 35 crore
MARKETING BUDGET: Rs 20 crore
BRAND TIE-UPS: Sony, Pantaloon, Citibank, Reliance Insurance, Xylitol, Airtel
APPEARANCES: Star Plus' *Voice of India*, Sony's *Jhalak Dikhla Jaa*
SPIN CYCLE: Ranbir's towel scene

working non-stop to promote the film, travelling to nine cities, including Indore, Hyderabad, Jaipur and Ahmedabad. They're getting a lot of default attention on news channels as well, whether it is Ranbir leading the *Ganesh visarjan* at R.K. Studios or Ranbir and Sonam going to the Siddhi Vinayak temple. Interviews with Bhansali, and the two guest stars in the movie, Salman Khan and Rani

movie is not new—but as Shah Rukh himself says, it depends on the movie. In recent times, *Ram Gopal Varma ki Aag* was promoted to its death. The movie was discussed threadbare by TV channels even before it was out, which didn't prevent viewers from giving it a thumbs down. Even now, there is a desperate sameness in the visibility campaigns, still a far cry from Hollywood films which, as a critic said, are designed to get children to buy toys and drag their parents to theme parks.

If Bollywood doesn't shift its stratagems now, going beyond what media analyst Prabhat Choudhary calls "the template of dance shows, news channel tie-ups and break up rumours", orchestrated noise about new releases will be in danger of degenerating into noise pollution. ■